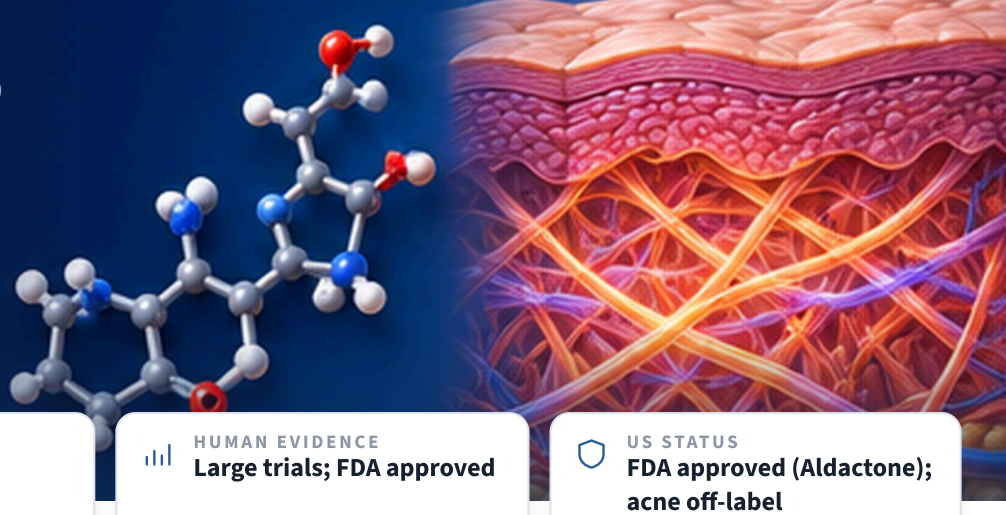
SKIN 06

Spironolactone

Aldosterone antagonist taken by mouth, a diuretic that also binds the androgen receptor



CLASS
Aldosterone antagonist (diuretic)

STUDIED FOR
Heart failure, blood pressure, acne

HUMAN EVIDENCE
Large trials; FDA approved

US STATUS
FDA approved (Aldactone); acne off-label

STUDIED FOR

- **Heart failure** — HUMAN
- **Blood pressure** — HUMAN
- **Edema** — HUMAN
- **Acne** — HUMAN

Acne trials enrolled women only. SAFA (410 women) and FASCE (133 women) tested acne. Neither tells us how it works or how it is tolerated in men.

HOW IT WORKS IN THE BODY

Spironolactone ▶ Aldosterone block ▶ Salt, water out ▶ Androgen receptor

- **Blocks aldosterone** at the kidney tubule, per the label
- **More sodium and water** are excreted while potassium is retained
- **Binds the androgen receptor;** the label describes anti-androgenic effects
- **In acne,** trial authors say it targets oil-gland androgen receptors

EVIDENCE & WHAT'S KNOWN

EVIDENCE

FDA APPROVED
LEVEL 5 OF 5

- Aldactone approved 1960
- Acne: SAFA, 410 women, 24 weeks
- Acne success 19% vs 6% (placebo) at week 12

NOT YET ESTABLISHED

- Acne use in men
- Acne mechanism in people

QUICK PRACTICAL INFO

HALF-LIFE
1.4 hours; active metabolites 13.8 to 16.5 hours

ROUTES STUDIED
By mouth (tablets, oral liquid)

PHARMACOKINETICS
Peak in 2.6 hours (canrenone 4.3); extensive metabolism

SOLD AS
Prescription tablets (Aldactone, generics)

MONITORED IN TRIALS
Potassium within 1 week, then regularly; kidney function

SPORT (WADA)
Prohibited at all times, class S5

REGULATORY

FDA	Approved (1960): heart, blood pressure, edema
FDA	Acne is off-label
DEA	Not a controlled substance
WADA	Prohibited at all times (S5)

REFERENCES

1. FDA, Aldactone prescribing information (DailyMed), Nov 2025
2. Santer et al., BMJ, SAFA trial of spironolactone for acne in women, May 2023
3. WADA, 2026 Prohibited List

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